

EXCEL LINE CHART

Show trends over time

03

WHEN TO USE

- Data has a **time field** (day, month, year) and **one number**.
- Answers: **Is it going up, down, or staying flat?**
- Use it for **trends, growth and seasonality** over time.

BUSINESS QUESTION

- How has monthly revenue changed this year?
- Which month had the highest revenue?
- Is revenue growing or declining?

DATA EXAMPLE

	A	B
1	Month	Revenue
2	Jan	42,000
3	Feb	45,500
4	Mar	51,000
5	Apr	48,500
6	May	58,000
7	Jun	66,500

DATA ANALYST USE CASE

Example: **Monthly Revenue**

QUESTION

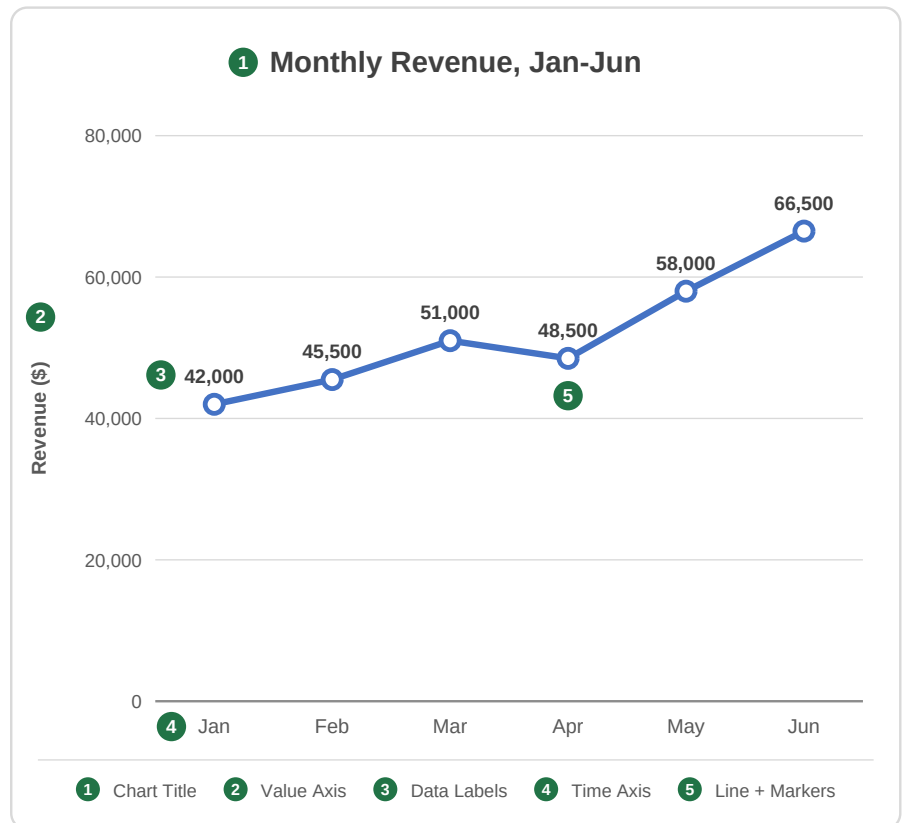
Is revenue growing?

CHART

Line Chart

INSIGHT

Revenue rose from 42,000 in January to 66,500 in June (+58%), with a small dip in April.



HOW TO CREATE IT IN EXCEL



- 1 **Select** the data, including the headers (A1:B7).
- 2 Go to the **Insert** tab and open the **Charts** group.
- 3 Click **Insert Line or Area Chart > 2-D Line > Line with Markers**.
- 4 Add a clear **Chart Title** that names the measure and time period.
- 5 **Format**: keep time in order, add labels for key points, and start the axis at a sensible value.

DO / DON'T

DO ✓

- ✓ Put time on the horizontal axis
- ✓ Keep dates in chronological order
- ✓ Use one clear line per measure
- ✓ Mark the peaks and key points

DON'T ✗

- ✗ Use it for unordered categories
- ✗ Plot more than 4-5 lines
- ✗ Skip months or mix time intervals
- ✗ Use 3-D or heavy effects



DATA ANALYST TIP

Use it when time and trend matter.

If the horizontal axis is not time, a column or bar chart is usually the better choice.